

WILL & ARIEL DURANT — SIMON & SCHUSTER · 1935-1950 — VOLUMES I-IV OF XI

The Story of Civilization

Volumes I-IV · From the first cities of Sumer to the death of Dante — thirty thousand years of human record, told as one continuous life.

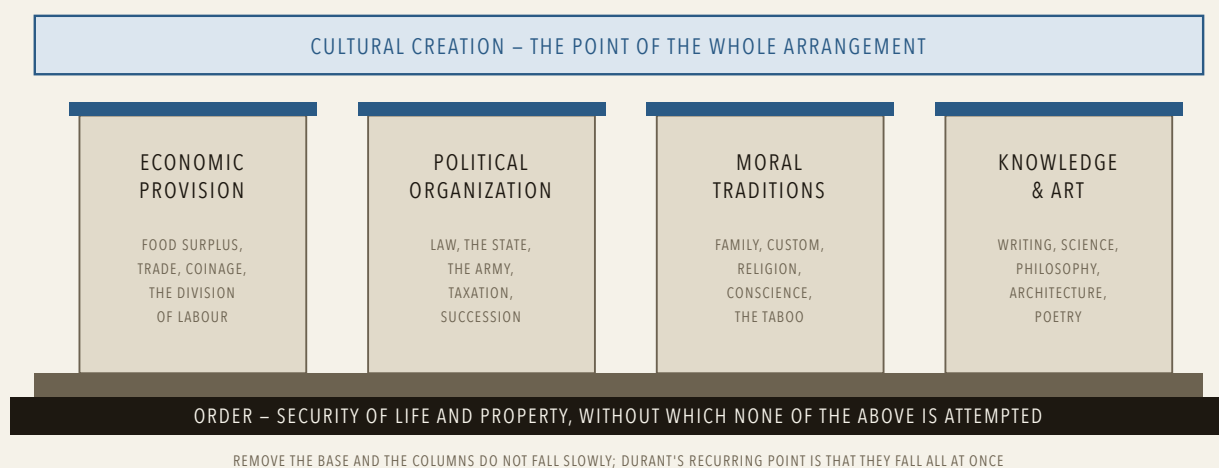
Durant set out to do what professional history had stopped attempting: to write the whole of a civilization at once — its economics, politics, religion, science, morals, art and thought — as a single narrative rather than four specialisms. **The organising idea is that civilization is not a possession but a performance: an order maintained against constant pressure, capable of collapse, and transmitted only by deliberate teaching.** These first four volumes carry that argument from the Nile to the Rhine, and from mud-brick granaries to Gothic vaults.

COVERED HERE	WRITTEN	EXTENT	SPAN	SERIES ENDS
Vols. I-IV OF ELEVEN	1935-1950 FIFTEEN YEARS	≈3,750 pp. ~1.5M WORDS	-30,000 → 1300 CE AT DANTE	1815 VOL. XI, 1975

Durant's premise is stated in the first pages of Volume I and never abandoned across the next forty years: **civilization is social order promoting cultural creation**. Order is the precondition; creation is the point. Everything he narrates is either a form of that order, a threat to it, or something made possible by it.

From that definition he derives four elements, and each volume is structured to give all four their turn — which is why a chapter on Athenian finance can sit beside a chapter on Athenian sculpture without apology. He called this *integral history*: the refusal to split a people into departments. The cost is obvious — no specialist would write this way — and the compensation is that you leave each volume with the texture of a civilization rather than a list of its kings.

PLATE 01 THE FOUR ELEMENTS OF CIVILIZATION

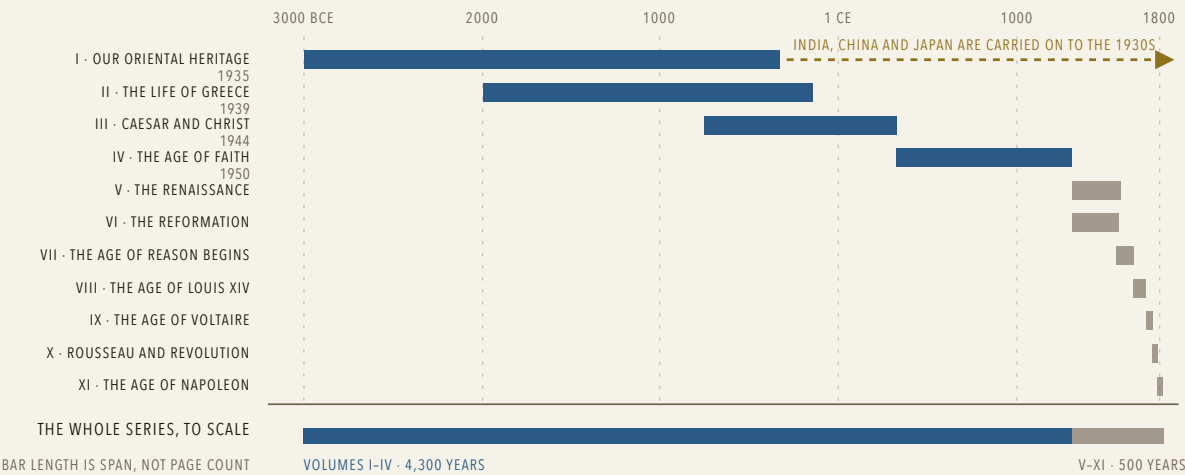


Durant's definition in structural form. Note what the diagram makes obvious and the prose sometimes hides: for him the arts are not decoration on top of history but the *reason* for narrating any of it. Wars and dynasties earn their pages only insofar as they explain why the roof stood or fell.

WHERE THESE FOUR VOLUMES SIT

The full series runs to eleven volumes and stops in 1815, in the middle of a projected twelfth on the nineteenth century that the Durants did not live to write. Volumes I–IV are the ancient and medieval half, and they are the four in which Durant is least constrained by the European archive and most willing to give Asia, Islam and Judaism their own weight.

PLATE 02 THE ELEVEN VOLUMES, AND THE FOUR READ HERE



Bar length is historical span, not page count – which is why Volume I looks enormous and is: it opens in the Palaeolithic and, for India, China and Japan, runs all the way to the 1930s. The compression is severe at the left end and loosens as the record thickens.

A READING NOTE

These four volumes overlap deliberately. Volume I carries the Near East to Alexander and then takes India, China and Japan to the modern day in one sweep; Volume II picks the Near East back up after Alexander; Volume III runs Rome from the founding to 325 CE; Volume IV starts at 325 and stops at 1300. Read in order they double back on themselves twice. That is a feature – Durant is following each civilization to its own natural ending rather than slicing the world by century.

THE FOUR VOLUMES AT A GLANCE

I · 1935	Our Oriental Heritage	Civilization is invented in the Near East, and the West inherits nearly all of its foundations from it. Then India, China and Japan, each carried to the present.
II · 1939	The Life of Greece	A small, poor, quarrelsome people invent rational enquiry, drama, and the citizen state – and cannot invent a way to stop fighting each other.
III · 1944	Caesar and Christ	Rome solves the problem Greece could not – political order at scale – and is then transformed from inside by a religion of the powerless.
IV · 1950	The Age of Faith	Three heirs quarrel over the ruins: Byzantium, Islam and the Latin West. Faith organises life for a thousand years, then generates the reason that will dissolve it.

Our Oriental Heritage

Civilization in Egypt and the Near East to the death of Alexander, and in India, China and Japan from the beginning to our own day.

SPAN	ARGUMENT	HALVES	HARDEST CHAPTER
c. 30,000 BCE → 1930s	The West is a debtor	Near East · Asia	The Establishment of Civilization

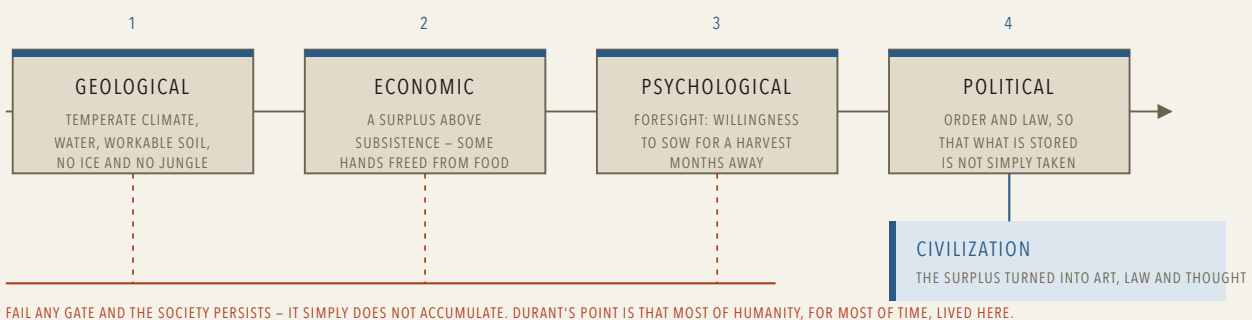
The title is the thesis. Durant opens the entire series by arguing that Europe is a late province of a much older world, and that almost every foundation the West treats as its own — agriculture, writing, law, coinage, monotheism, the arch, the calendar, the alphabet — was laid in Asia or Africa before a Greek wrote a line. Only after four hundred pages of Near East does he turn to India, China and Japan, and he takes each of those to the twentieth century in a single run.

Part I The Establishment of Civilization

Palaeolithic → c. 3500 BCE

Durant begins before history, with the question of what has to be true before a civilization can exist at all. His answer is a set of preconditions that are mostly not achievements: a climate that is neither too harsh nor too kind, soil that rewards work, an economic surplus, and — the one that recurs through all eleven volumes — **security**. Where life is uncertain, men do not plant trees whose fruit they will not live to eat.

PLATE 03 THE GATES A SOCIETY PASSES BEFORE IT CAN CREATE



The sequence matters more than the list. Durant insists the psychological gate is the hardest and the least noticed: agriculture demands that a people learn to defer gratification across a season, which is a moral revolution before it is a technical one.

The transition from hunting to tillage is treated as the great watershed, and — characteristically — Durant refuses to call it simple progress. The farmer is shorter-lived, worse fed and more diseased than the hunter; he works longer; he acquires property and therefore theft, boundaries and therefore war, storage and therefore taxes. What he gains is *continuity*: the possibility that his grandson will begin from where he stopped.

THE HUNTER		THE TILLER	
VARIED DIET, MORE PROTEIN	FOOD	MONOTONOUS GRAIN DIET, FAMINE RISK	
TALLER, STRONGER, FEWER CARIES	BODY	SHORTER, MORE DISEASE, EPIDEMICS	
FEW POSSESSIONS, NO THEFT TO SPEAK OF	PROPERTY	LAND, GRANARY, HERD – AND LAW TO DEFEND THEM	
SMALL BANDS, RAIDS NOT WARS	WAR	FIXED WEALTH WORTH CONQUERING: ORGANISED WAR	
WOMAN GATHERS; STATUS RELATIVELY HIGH	SEXES	MAN PLOUGHS; PATRIARCHY HARDENS	
NOTHING ACCUMULATES BETWEEN GENERATIONS	TIME	SURPLUS, CITIES, WRITING, MEMORY – THE ONE LINE THAT DECIDES IT	

DURANT GRANTS NEARLY EVERY PARTICULAR TO THE HUNTER AND STILL CALLS THE TRADE WORTH MAKING, BECAUSE ONLY THE TILLER CAN HAND ANYTHING ON.

The same ledger, drawn from different evidence, reappears in Diamond and in the Durants' own *Lessons of History*. What is distinctive here is the conclusion: civilization is justified not by making individual lives better – Durant thinks it often did not – but by making them cumulative.

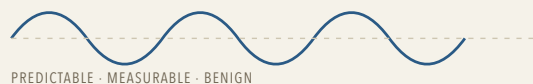
Part II **The Near East — Sumer to Persia**

c. 3500 – 330 BCE

Durant gives Sumer the credit that popular history still tends to give Egypt: the first cities, the first writing, the first schools, the first law codes, the first arch and vault, the sexagesimal arithmetic that survives in our clocks and circles. Then Egypt, Babylonia, Assyria, Judea and Persia follow in turn — a relay in which each empire inherits the apparatus of the last and adds one thing of its own.

THE NILE

FLOOD ARRIVES WITHIN DAYS OF THE SAME DATE, EVERY YEAR, FOR MILLENNIA



WHAT DURANT READS OUT OF IT

SERENE, OPTIMISTIC RELIGION; DEATH AS CONTINUATION
A SINGLE GOD-KING; UNBROKEN DYNASTIC CONTINUITY
GEOMETRY AND THE 365-DAY CALENDAR, FROM MEASURING FLOOD
ART THAT CHANGES ALMOST NOTHING IN THREE THOUSAND YEARS

THE TIGRIS & EUPHRATES

FLOOD ARRIVES LATE, EARLY, OR CATASTROPHICALLY; THE CHANNEL ITSELF MOVES



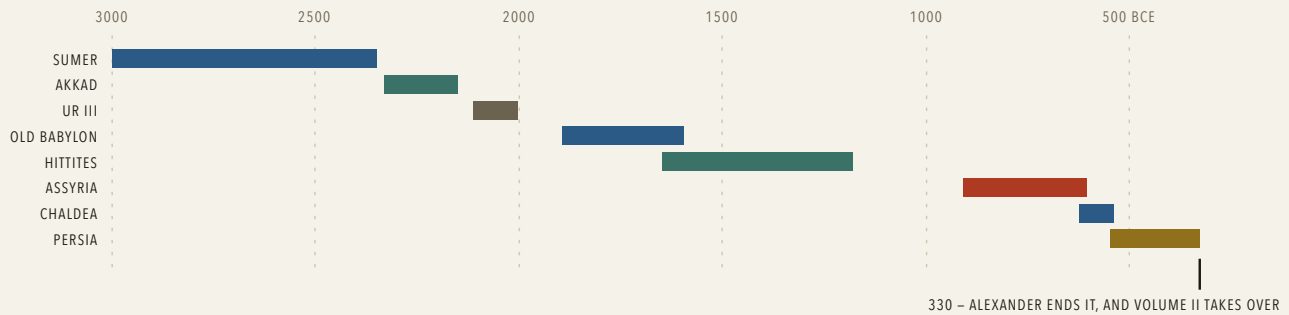
AND OUT OF THIS

ANXIOUS RELIGION; CAPRICIOUS GODS TO BE APPEASED
A DISMAL UNDERWORLD; NO COMFORTABLE AFTERLIFE
DIVINATION, OMENS, ASTROLOGY – READING INTENT IN NATURE
COMPETING CITY-STATES; DYNASTIES THAT FALL AND ARE REPLACED

A SCHEMATIC OF AN ARGUMENT, NOT A PROOF. DURANT LEANS ON IT HARD; MODERN SCHOLARSHIP TREATS IT AS SUGGESTIVE RATHER THAN CAUSAL.

One of Durant's signature moves: run a physical fact forward into theology, politics and art, and see how much it explains. Read it as a hypothesis with real explanatory reach and no way to test it – the honest verdict on a good deal of the environmental determinism in these volumes.

PLATE 06 THE NEAR EASTERN RELAY - C. 3000 - 330 BCE



WHAT EACH ONE HANDS ON

SUMER - CUNEIFORM, THE WHEEL, THE ARCH, SCHOOLS, BASE-60

AKKAD - SARGON, C. 2334: THE FIRST EMPIRE OVER CITIES

UR III - UR-NAMMU'S CODE, THE OLDEST LAW TEXT WE HOLD

OLD BABYLON - HAMMURABI, C. 1750: 282 LAWS CUT IN STONE

BAND = PERIOD OF DOMINANCE, NOT OF EXISTENCE. WHAT EACH HANDS ON OUTLIVES THE STATE THAT MADE IT.

HITTITES - IRON WORKING, AND A TREATY WITH EGYPT AT KADESH

ASSYRIA - THE TERROR STATE; SIEGE ENGINEERING; A GREAT LIBRARY

CHALDEA - NEBUCHADNEZZAR; ASTRONOMY AS A SCIENCE OF RECORD

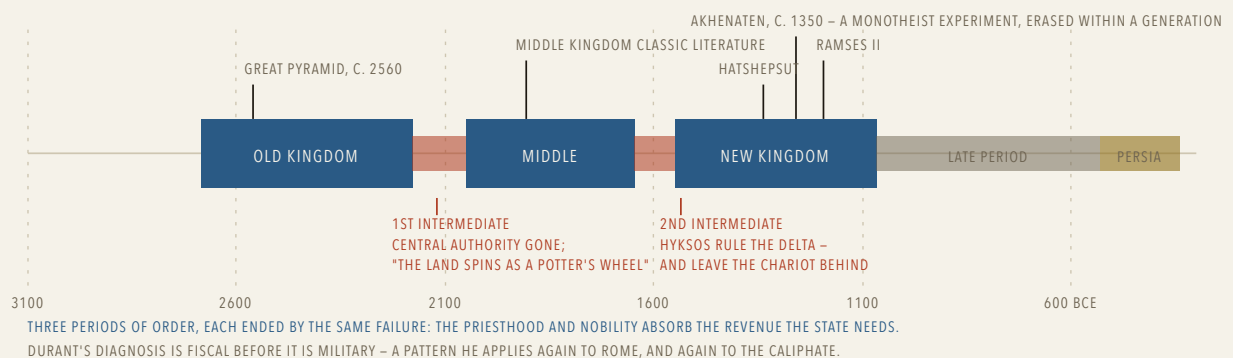
PERSIA - SATRAPIES, ROYAL ROAD, RELAY POST, COIN, TOLERANCE

Sumer's contribution is disproportionate and comes first; everything after is, in Durant's telling, elaboration and administration. Note the Persian band: he singles out Cyrus's policy of religious tolerance as a genuine political invention, and the one the Greeks failed to copy.

EGYPT - THE LONG STILLNESS

Egypt receives Durant's most affectionate writing and his sharpest criticism. He is dazzled by the engineering and repelled by what it cost, and he keeps returning to the strangeness of a culture that solved its problems early and then held the solution for three thousand years — the same gods, the same script, the same canon of proportion in sculpture, through more time than separates us from Homer.

PLATE 07 EGYPT'S SPINE - THREE KINGDOMS, TWO COLLAPSES



Durant treats the intermediate periods as the informative parts. Order is the exception being explained; the pyramids are what a state can do when it captures the whole surplus, and the collapses are what happens when it can no longer capture it.

HAMMURABI'S REAL INNOVATION

Not the content — much of the code restates older Sumerian practice, and Ur-Nammu's is three centuries older — but the *publication*. The laws are cut into an eight-foot diorite stele and set up where they can be consulted, with a preamble announcing that the king's purpose is that "the strong may not oppress the weak." Durant marks this as the birth of a specific political idea: that power should be answerable to a written rule it did not invent on the spot.

THE SAME INJURY · THREE DIFFERENT PRICES

Part III India

VICTIM: AWILUM
(NOBLE)

VICTIM: MUŠKENUM
(COMMONER)

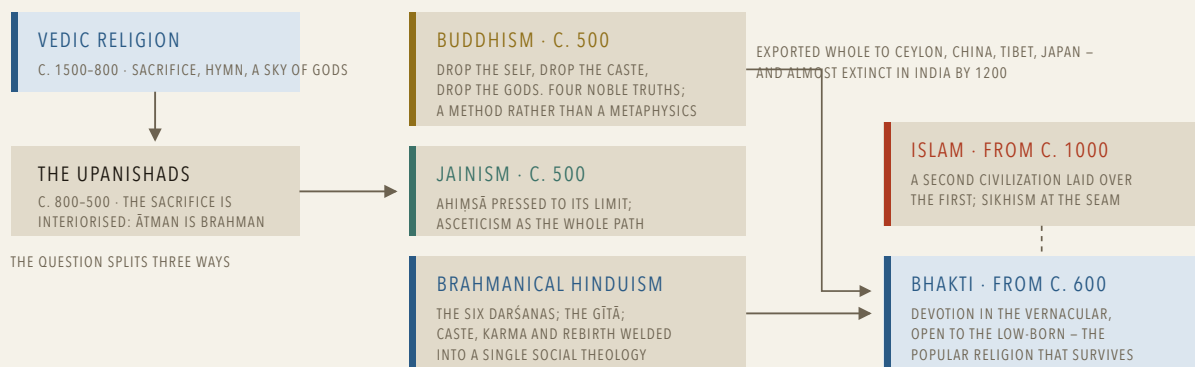
VICTIM: WARDUM
(SLAVE)

c. 3000 BCE → 1930s

Durant's India chapters were written when Mohenjo-daro and Harappa had only just been excavated, and his excitement at a civilization suddenly pushed back two thousand years is audible. He then runs the whole subcontinent forward in one arc: Vedic religion, the Upanishadic turn inward, the two great heresies of Buddhism and Jainism, Maurya and Gupta, the Muslim conquests, the Mughals, and the British — ending, in 1935, with a frankly anti-colonial account and a long appreciation of the man he calls "the greatest figure of our time," Gandhi.

COULD HE BE THE FIRST TO UNDERSTAND THE INDIAN CASE. WHAT IS BEING INVENTED IS THAT THE PRICE IS FIXED IN ADVANCE, WRITTEN DOWN, AND THE SAME TOMORROW. SCHEMATIC: THE CODE IS MORE VARIOUS THAN A CODE.

PLATE 09 THE INDIAN RELIGIOUS LINEAGE



DURANT'S ORGANISING CLAIM FOR INDIA: IT IS THE ONE CIVILIZATION WHERE THE CENTRAL QUESTION WAS NEVER POLITICAL. DYNASTIES COME AND GO ALMOST UNREMARKED; WHAT IS CONTINUOUS, AND WHAT HE THINKS INDIA EXPORTED, IS A TECHNIQUE OF INTROSPECTION.

The diagram flattens a great deal – the darśanas are not one thing, and "Hinduism" as a unified object is partly a colonial construction Durant inherits. But the structural point holds: the Upanishadic turn is the hinge, and Buddhism is best read as one answer among several to a question the Upanishads had already posed.

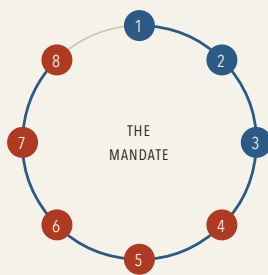
Two Indian political moments get extended treatment. **Ashoka** (r. c. 268–232 BCE), who conquered Kalinga, was appalled by his own victory, converted to Buddhism and spent the rest of his reign carving edicts of tolerance and non-violence onto rocks across the subcontinent — Durant calls him, without much hedging, the greatest ruler in history. And the **Gupta** centuries (c. 320–550 CE), which he presents as India's classical age: Kālidāsa in poetry, the decimal place-value system with a symbol for zero, Āryabhaṭa's astronomy, and the surgical literature that Arab physicians would later carry west.

Part IV China and Japan

c. 2000 BCE → 1930s

China is where Durant's admiration is most open. He is drawn to a civilization that produced, very early, a moral philosophy without a church, a governing class selected by examination rather than birth, and a run of technical inventions — paper, printing, the compass, gunpowder, porcelain, the sternpost rudder, paper currency — that reached Europe centuries later and remade it.

PLATE 10 THE DYNASTIC CYCLE



- 1 A VIGOROUS FOUNDER TAKES THE MANDATE OF HEAVEN
- 2 LAND REDISTRIBUTED; TAXES LIGHT; THE TREASURY FILLS
- 3 PEACE, GROWTH, HIGH CULTURE – THE "GOLDEN REIGN"
- 4 COURT EXPENSE GROWS; LAND RE-CONCENTRATES
- 5 GREAT ESTATES FALL OFF THE TAX ROLLS; REVENUE COLLAPSES
- 6 THE LEVY FALLS ON THE PEASANTRY ALONE
- 7 FLOOD, FAMINE, EUNUCH FACTION, PRESSURE FROM THE STEPPE
- 8 REBELLION – THE MANDATE IS SAID TO BE WITHDRAWN

THE CYCLE, RUN EIGHT TIMES

SHANG · C. 1600–1046 · BRONZE, ORACLE BONE, THE FIRST SCRIPT

ZHOU · 1046–256 · THE MANDATE OF HEAVEN IS FORMULATED

QIN · 221–206 · UNIFICATION, STANDARDISATION, LEGALIST TERROR

HAN · 206 BCE–220 CE · CONFUCIAN BUREAUCRACY; PAPER; THE SILK ROAD
– THEN THREE CENTURIES OF DIVISION –

TANG · 618–907 · THE EXAMINATION SYSTEM MATURES; LI BAI, DU FU

SONG · 960–1279 · PRINTING, GUNPOWDER, COMPASS, PAPER MONEY

YUAN · 1279–1368 · MONGOL RULE; MARCO POLO'S REPORT

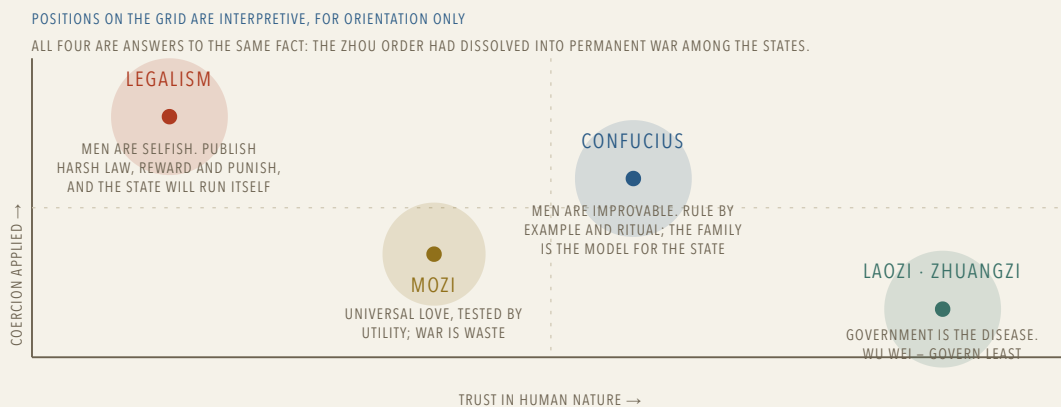
MING · 1368–1644 · THE TREASURE FLEETS, THEN THE DOOR CLOSES

QING · 1644–1912 · MANCHU RULE ENDS IN A REPUBLIC

DURANT'S READING: THE CONSTANT IS NOT THE DYNASTY BUT THE BUREAUCRACY, WHICH SURVIVES EVERY COLLAPSE AND REBUILDS THE STATE.

Note the mechanism at the bottom of the wheel – tax-exempt great estates strangling the fisc – is precisely the diagnosis Durant gave Egypt's collapses and will give Rome's. It is the closest thing in these four volumes to a general law.

PLATE 11 THE HUNDRED SCHOOLS · FOUR ANSWERS TO ONE CRISIS



The historical outcome is the interesting part: Qin unified China on Legalist principles and lasted fifteen years; the Han kept the Qin machinery and painted it Confucian, and that hybrid – legalist bones, Confucian language – governed China for two thousand years.

Japan gets the shortest treatment of the four Asian sections and the most ambivalent. Durant admires the aesthetic discipline — the Heian court that produced *The Tale of Genji* around the year 1000, arguably the world's first novel and written by a woman; the Zen-inflected arts of the Ashikaga period; the two and a half centuries of sealed peace under the Tokugawa. Writing in 1935, he ends on the militarisation of the Meiji inheritance with an unmistakable note of alarm.

MESOPOTAMIA	WRITING (CUNEIFORM) · THE WHEEL · THE PLOUGH · THE ARCH AND VAULT BASE-60 ARITHMETIC – OUR 60 MINUTES AND 360 DEGREES THE SEVEN-DAY WEEK · THE LUNAR CALENDAR · IRRIGATION AT SCALE WRITTEN LAW · THE CITY ITSELF · THE SCHOOL · THE EPIC (GILGAMESH)	→ GREECE ROME AND, MUCH LATER, EUROPE
EGYPT	THE 365-DAY SOLAR CALENDAR · PRACTICAL GEOMETRY FROM LAND SURVEY PAPYRUS · MONUMENTAL STONE ARCHITECTURE · THE COLUMN MEDICINE AS A WRITTEN DISCIPLINE · THE FIRST SURVIVING SURGICAL TEXTS	
LEVANT	THE ALPHABET – PHOENICIAN, AND EVERY ALPHABET AFTER IT ETHICAL MONOTHEISM · THE SABBATH · THE PROPHETIC CONSCIENCE LONG-DISTANCE SEABORNE TRADE AS A BUSINESS	
PERSIA	COINED MONEY (LYDIA, ADOPTED AND SPREAD BY PERSIA) IMPERIAL ADMINISTRATION: SATRAPIES, ROAD SYSTEM, RELAY POST, TOLERANCE	
INDIA	DECIMAL PLACE VALUE AND THE ZERO – VIA BAGHDAD, THEN LATIN EUROPE ALGEBRA'S RAW MATERIALS · TRIGONOMETRIC SINE · COTTON · SUGAR · CHESS INOCULATION · PLASTIC SURGERY · THE CONCEPT OF INFINITY IN ARITHMETIC	
CHINA	PAPER · PRINTING (BLOCK, THEN MOVABLE TYPE) · THE MAGNETIC COMPASS GUNPOWDER · PORCELAIN · SILK · PAPER MONEY · THE STERNPOST RUDDER	

The point of the ledger is not that Greece contributed nothing – Volume II is 750 pages arguing the opposite – but that the Greek achievement is an *edit*, performed on an inheritance, by a people who arrived late and said so. Herodotus is quite clear that the Greeks got their gods, their letters and their geometry from abroad; it is later Europe that forgot.

"It is a mistake to think of Europe as the mother of civilization. She is rather its child, and its heir."

THE SENSE OF VOLUME I'S ARGUMENT, COMPRESSED

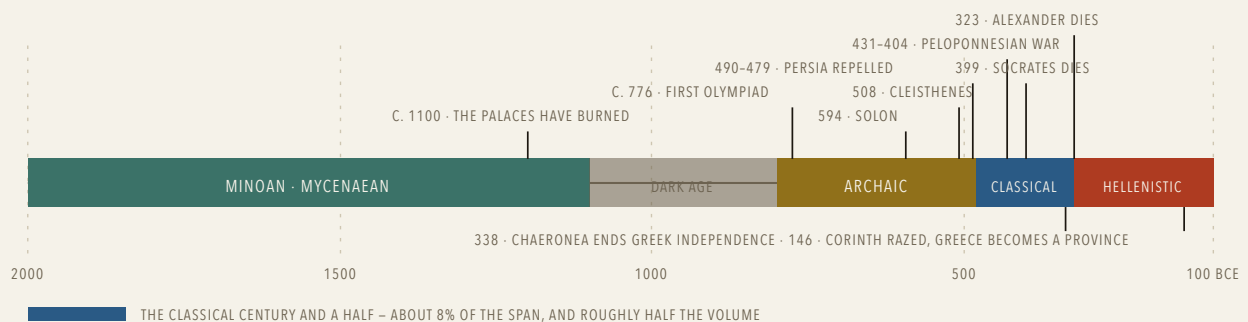
The Life of Greece

Greek civilization from the beginnings, and civilization in the Near East from the death of Alexander, to the Roman conquest.

SPAN	ARGUMENT	PEAK	WRITTEN
c. 2000 – 146 BCE	Freedom created it and destroyed it	Athens, 480–404	as Europe went to war

Volume II was published in 1939 and reads like it. Durant's Greece is a civilization that invents almost everything the West means by intellectual life — the demonstrative proof, the written constitution, tragedy, history as inquiry, the idea that nature has laws — and then destroys itself in a twenty-seven-year war between its two leading states because it cannot invent a federation. He states the moral bluntly and repeatedly: **the Greeks fell not to a better civilization but to a simpler one, and only after they had exhausted themselves.**

PLATE 13 THE GREEK SPINE · 2000 – 146 BCE



Durant spends roughly half the volume inside the narrow blue band. He is aware of the distortion and defends it: this is where the surviving evidence is, and it is also, on his reading, where the interesting things actually happened.

Bk. I The Aegean Prelude and the Coming of the Polis

c. 2000 – 500 BCE

Durant was writing thirteen years before Michael Ventris deciphered Linear B, so his Minoans are still a mysterious non-Greek people known only through Evans's excavation and the frescoes. What he draws from Knossos is a picture of a maritime, unwallled, apparently peaceable and startlingly modern-looking civilization — running water, women in public life, an art of movement rather than of monuments — destroyed around 1400 BCE by causes he cannot name.

The Dark Age that follows he treats as a genuine loss: writing disappears for four centuries, population falls, and Greece has to begin again. What emerges is the *polis* — small, fiercely independent, defined by a citizen body rather than a king, and multiplied by colonisation until Greek cities ring the Mediterranean "like frogs about a pond," in Plato's phrase. Durant makes the smallness structural: a

state you can walk across in a day can be governed by its members in person, and cannot be governed any other way.

PLATE 14 TWO SOLUTIONS TO THE SAME PROBLEM

SPARTA	ATHENS
SOLVE THE PROBLEM OF ORDER, PERMANENTLY	SOLVE THE PROBLEM OF PARTICIPATION
A HELOT POPULATION PERHAPS SEVENFOLD THE CITIZENS	A CITIZEN BODY TOO LARGE TO BE COMMANDED AND TOO POOR TO BE BOUGHT
TWO KINGS, A GEROUSIA, FIVE EPHORS; THE ASSEMBLY ACCLAIMS	CONSTITUTION ASSEMBLY OF ALL CITIZENS; COUNCIL OF 500 BY LOT; JURY COURTS OF HUNDREDS
LAND ASSIGNED, HELOTS FARM IT; COINAGE REFUSED; TRADE DESPISED	ECONOMY SILVER, OLIVES, POTTERY, SHIPPING, EMPIRE TRIBUTE; SLAVERY THROUGHOUT
THE AGÔGĒ FROM AGE SEVEN – THE STATE RAISES THE CHILD	EDUCATION PRIVATE, INFORMAL, RHETORICAL; THE SOPHISTS SELL IT FOR A FEE
TRAINED, PROPRTIED, PUBLICLY OUTSPOKEN – UNUSUAL IN GREECE	WOMEN SECLUDED, UNSCHOOLED, WITHOUT PROPERTY OR PUBLIC VOICE
NO PHILOSOPHY, LITTLE ART, NO SURVIVING LITERATURE OF ITS OWN	CULTURE TRAGEDY, COMEDY, HISTORY, PHILOSOPHY, THE PARTHENON
WINS THE WAR IN 404 – AND IS BROKEN AT LEUCTRA BY 371	OUTCO LOSSES THE WAR IN 404 – AND ITS IDEAS OUTLIVE EVERY GREEK STATE

Durant refuses the easy contrast. He is candid that Athens rested on slavery and on tribute extracted from allies, and that Spartan women were freer than Athenian ones. His judgement is comparative, not moral: Sparta bought stability by refusing to change, and had nothing left when change came anyway.

Bk. II The Great Age — Persia Repelled, Athens Ascendant

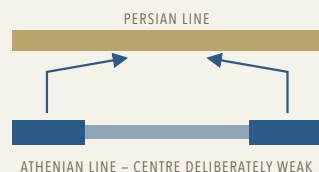
499 – 431 BCE

The Persian Wars occupy Durant less as military history than as the event that gave the Greeks their self-conception. A collection of quarrelling cities, badly outnumbered, defeated the largest empire on earth twice in a decade — and drew from it the conclusion that free men fighting for their own laws beat subjects fighting for a king. Everything confident in the fifty years after 480 traces back to that inference.

PLATE 15 THREE BATTLES THAT DECIDED IT

MARATHON · 490

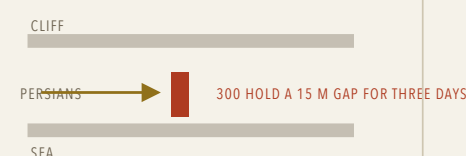
THIN THE CENTRE, WEIGHT THE WINGS, ENVELOP



PERSIANS BREAK THE CENTRE, ARE TAKEN ON BOTH FLANKS
HERODOTUS: 6,400 PERSIAN DEAD TO 192 ATHENIAN

THERMOPYLAE & SALAMIS · 480

FIGHT WHERE NUMBERS CANNOT BE USED



THEN THE SAME TRICK AT SEA: THEMISTOCLES LURES THE FLEET INTO THE SALAMIS NARROWS, WHERE 1,200 SHIPS CANNOT DEPLOY AGAINST 380. THE INVASION LOSES ITS SUPPLY LINE.

DURANT'S NOTE: ATHENS GAVE UP ITS CITY TO WIN AT SEA – THE FLEET, AND THEREFORE THE ROWERS, BECOME THE STATE

PLATAEA · 479

HEAVY INFANTRY ON GROUND OF ITS CHOOSING



BRONZE, EIGHT RANKS DEEP, SHIELD OVERLAPPING SHIELD. AGAINST WICKER SHIELDS AND LINEN IT IS NOT A CONTEST – PROVIDED THE PHALANX KEEPS ITS LINE AND PICKS THE FIELD.

THE PERSIAN LAND ARMY IS DESTROYED. PERSIA NEVER INVADES GREECE AGAIN – 150 YEARS LATER, GREECE INVADES PERSIA.

Three variations on one theme, and Durant draws the theme out: in every case the Greeks won by forcing a battle in which the Persian advantages – numbers, cavalry, archery, manoeuvre – could not be brought to bear. It is the same insight the Roman legion will later invert against the phalanx itself.

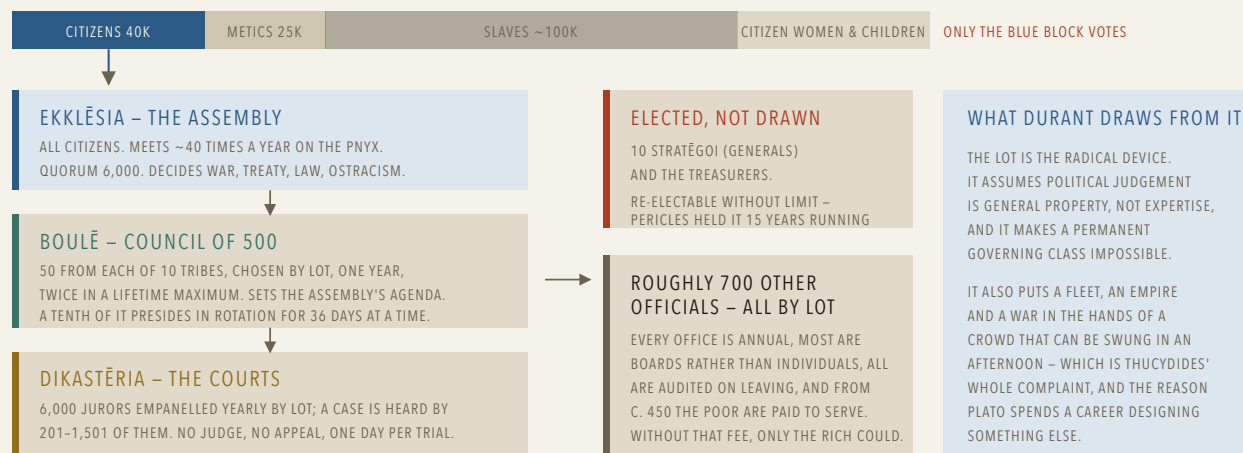
HOW THE DEMOCRACY ACTUALLY WORKED

Durant is unusually concrete about the machinery, because he thinks the machinery is the point. Athenian democracy was not representative; it was direct, and it distributed office by *lot* rather than election on the theory that any citizen could serve and that election favours the rich and famous. Only

two kinds of post were filled by vote — the generals and the treasurers — on the ground that competence there was not evenly distributed.

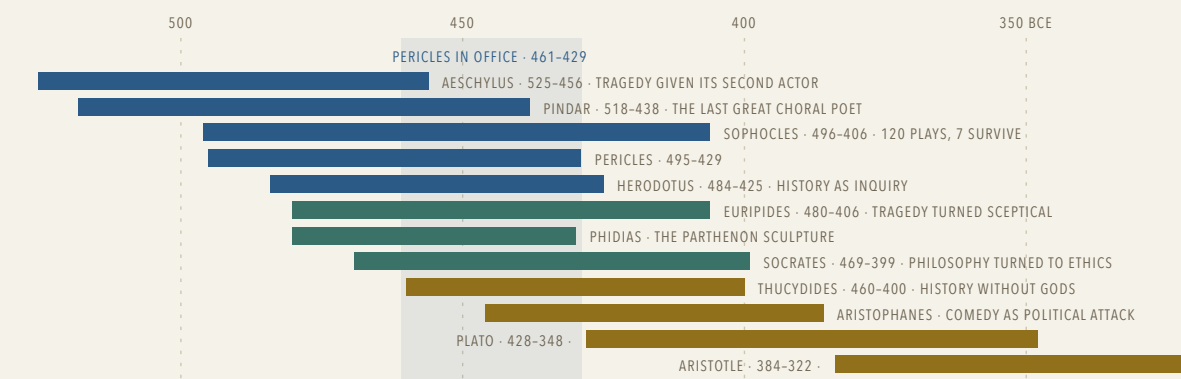
PLATE 16 THE ATHENIAN MACHINE, C. 430 BCE

WHO IS IN ATTICA, C. 430 BCE – FIGURES ARE ESTIMATES AND MUCH DISPUTED



Durant's verdict is double-edged and he does not resolve it: this is the most participatory constitution any large society has ever operated, and it voted for the Sicilian expedition, condemned the generals of Arginusae en masse, and executed Socrates. Both facts follow from the same design.

PLATE 17 THE SIMULTANEITY – ONE SMALL CITY, TWO GENERATIONS



A CITIZEN BODY OF PERHAPS FORTY THOUSAND ADULT MEN. DURANT RETURNS TO THIS ARITHMETIC WHENEVER HE IS ACCUSED OF EXAGGERATING GREECE: THE DENSITY, NOT THE QUALITY ALONE, IS WHAT NEEDS EXPLAINING.

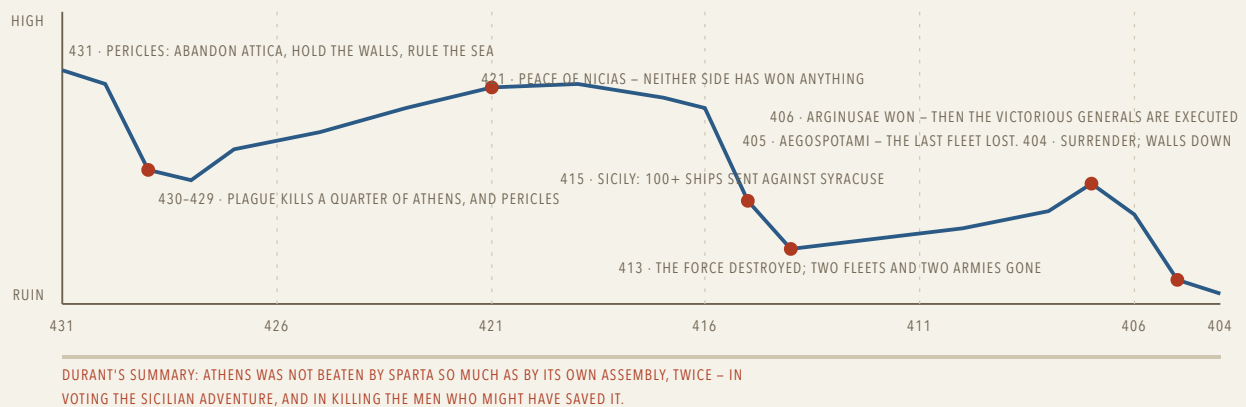
Bars are approximate lifespans. The plate is the argument of Durant's central chapters in one image – that the classical achievement is not spread across the Greek world but concentrated, absurdly, in one city over about seventy years.

Bk. III The Suicide of Greece

431 – 338 BCE

The Delian League, formed in 478 to keep Persia out, becomes within a generation an Athenian empire: the treasury is moved from Delos to Athens in 454, allied tribute pays for the Parthenon, and secession is treated as revolt. Durant is unsparing here — the funding of the classical achievement was, in plain terms, protection money — and he makes the empire the direct cause of the war that ends the age.

PLATE 18 THE PELOPONNESIAN WAR - A TWENTY-SEVEN-YEAR FALL



The shape matters more than any single point on it. What Durant wants the reader to see is a democracy that could survive plague, invasion and the loss of its greatest man, and could not survive its own capacity for a bad decision taken enthusiastically.

The Greek achievement in thought is a single unbroken conversation. Almost every position later philosophy takes is staked out inside two hundred years, in a territory smaller than Portugal, by men who mostly knew each other.

THE THREAD OF DURANT'S CHAPTERS ON THE SCHOOLS

PLATE 19 THE LINE OF DESCENT IN GREEK THOUGHT

C. 600 - WHAT IS THE WORLD MADE OF?

THALES - ANAXIMANDER
MILETUS. EXPLAIN NATURE BY NATURE - THE FOUNDING MOVE

PYTHAGORAS
NUMBER IS THE REALITY

HERACLITUS - PARMENIDES
ALL FLOWS / NOTHING CHANGES

DEMOCRITUS
ATOMS AND THE VOID

C. 450 - THE SOPHISTS TURN THE QUESTION ON MAN

PROTAGORAS
"MAN IS THE MEASURE" - RHETORIC FOR HIRE, TRUTH RELATIVE

SOCRATES - D. 399
DEFINITION, CROSS-EXAMINATION, "THE UNEXAMINED LIFE"

PLATO - ACADEMY, 387
FORMS; THE PHILOSOPHER-KING

AFTER ALEXANDER - HOW TO LIVE

STOICS - ACCEPT THE ORDER

EPICUREANS - WITHDRAW

SCEPTICS - SUSPEND JUDGEMENT

THE POLIS IS GONE; PHILOSOPHY STOPS DESIGNING STATES AND STARTS CONSOLING INDIVIDUALS. ROME WILL IMPORT THE STOICS WHOLESALE.

ARISTOTLE - LYCEUM, 335
LOGIC, BIOLOGY, THE MIDDLE WAY

DURANT'S STRUCTURAL OBSERVATION: THE SHIFT FROM COSMOLOGY TO ETHICS TRACKS THE LOSS OF POLITICAL AGENCY EXACTLY. MEN ASK HOW TO LIVE WELL IN A WORLD THEY CANNOT ALTER ONLY ONCE THEY HAVE STOPPED BEING ABLE TO ALTER IT.

Bk. IV Alexander and the Hellenistic Dispersal

338 - 146 BCE

The right-hand column is the transition into Volume III. Stoicism is the Greek export that matters most to Rome - it gives an imperial governing class a private ethic compatible with obedience, and it supplies the vocabulary Christianity will borrow.

Philip of Macedon settles the Greek question at Chaeronea in 338 by conquest; his son spends eleven years carrying Greek language, coinage and city-planning to the Indus and dies at thirty-two, leaving no arrangement for what follows. Durant's verdict on Alexander is characteristically split: a destroyer of a great deal, and the involuntary founder of the first genuinely cosmopolitan culture.

PLATE 20 ELEVEN YEARS OUT, THREE CENTURIES OF CONSEQUENCE

THE ROUTE · 334-323



ROUGHLY 20,000 KM ON FOOT IN ELEVEN YEARS, UNDEFEATED. THEN DYSENTERY OR FEVER AT BABYLON, AGED 32, WITH NO HEIR AND NO PLAN.

THE DIVISION · THE GENERALS CARVE IT UP OVER FORTY YEARS OF WAR

PTOLEMIES · EGYPT ALEXANDRIA: LIBRARY, MUSEUM, EUCLID. LASTS TO CLEOPATRA, 30 BCE	SELEUCIDS · ASIA GREEK CITIES FROM SYRIA TO PERSIA; LOSES THE EAST, THEN ROME TAKES THE REST	ANTIGONIDS · MACEDON HOLDS GREECE DOWN UNTIL ROME REMOVES IT AT PYDNA, 168	PERGAMUM & THE REST WILLED TO ROME IN 133 – THE EMPIRE ACQUIRED BY LEGACY
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Durant's Hellenistic chapters are among the volume's best and least read. The successor kingdoms are where Greek culture becomes portable – detached from the citizen assembly that produced it, translated into an administrative language for non-Greeks, and thereby made available to Rome and to Christianity.

PLATE 21 ALEXANDRIA · HOW CLOSE THE ANCIENTS CAME

MADE IN THE HELLENISTIC WORLD

EUCLID · THE ELEMENTS – DEDUCTION AS A SYSTEM

C. 300 BCE

ARISTARCHUS · THE EARTH ORBITS THE SUN

C. 260 BCE

ERATOSTHENES · EARTH'S CIRCUMFERENCE, FROM TWO SHADOWS

C. 240 BCE

ARCHIMEDES · HYDROSTATICS, THE LEVER, AN EARLY CALCULUS OF AREAS

C. 230 BCE

HIPPARCHUS · PRECESSION OF THE EQUINOXES; A STAR CATALOGUE

C. 130 BCE

HERO · A STEAM-DRIVEN SPHERE, TREATED AS A CURIOSITY

C. 60 CE

MATCHED AGAIN IN EUROPE

NEVER LOST – THE TEXTBOOK UNTIL THE 1900S

COPERNICUS, 1543 – EIGHTEEN CENTURIES LATER

WITHIN ~2% OF THE TRUE FIGURE; UNMATCHED UNTIL THE 1600S

GALILEO AND NEWTON WORK FROM HIM DIRECTLY

TYCHO BRAHE'S CATALOGUE, 1590S

NEWCOMEN'S ENGINE, 1712 – SIXTEEN CENTURIES LATER

DURANT'S QUESTION, WHICH HE ASKS AND DOES NOT FULLY ANSWER: WHY DID THIS STOP? HIS CANDIDATES – SLAVE LABOUR REMOVED THE INCENTIVE TO MECHANISE; SCIENCE STAYED A GENTLEMAN'S PURSUIT, CUT OFF FROM THE CRAFTS; AND THE SCHOOLS TURNED TO CONSOLATION ONCE THE CITIES LOST THEIR INDEPENDENCE.

This plate is the strongest thing in Volume II and Durant knows it. It also sets up the central puzzle of Volume IV: the knowledge was not destroyed by barbarians so much as left unused, and its recovery runs through Arabic, not Latin.

Caesar and Christ

Roman civilization and Christianity from their beginnings to A.D. 325.

SPAN	ARGUMENT	TWO SUBJECTS	THE FAMOUS LINE
753 BCE – 325 CE	Rome fell inward first	an empire and a faith	"destroyed itself within"

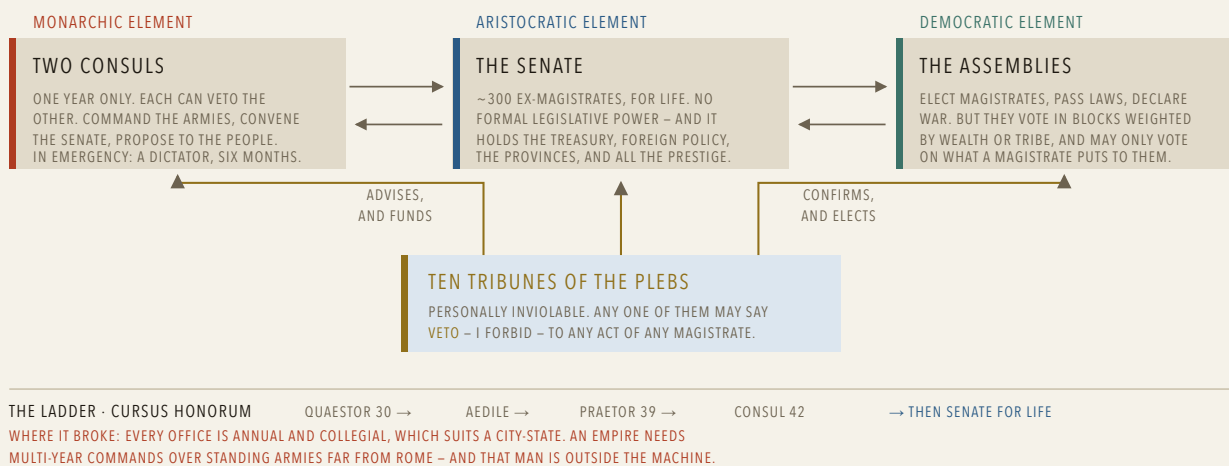
The title names a collision. Durant runs two histories side by side — a state that solves the political problem Greece could not, and a religion born in one of its remotest provinces — and shows them converging until, in 325, a Roman emperor presides over a council of Christian bishops. His organising claim about the fall is stated early and repeated: **Rome was an empty shell before either the Christians or the Germans touched it.**

Bk. I The Republic

753 – 146 BCE

Durant's Republic is above all a machine that worked — for four hundred years, under strain, with no written constitution and no theory behind it. Polybius, a Greek hostage in Rome, thought he saw why: the Romans had accidentally built the mixed constitution the philosophers had only described, balancing a monarchic element, an aristocratic one and a democratic one so that each could block the others.

PLATE 22 THE REPUBLIC'S BALANCE, AND WHERE IT GAVE WAY

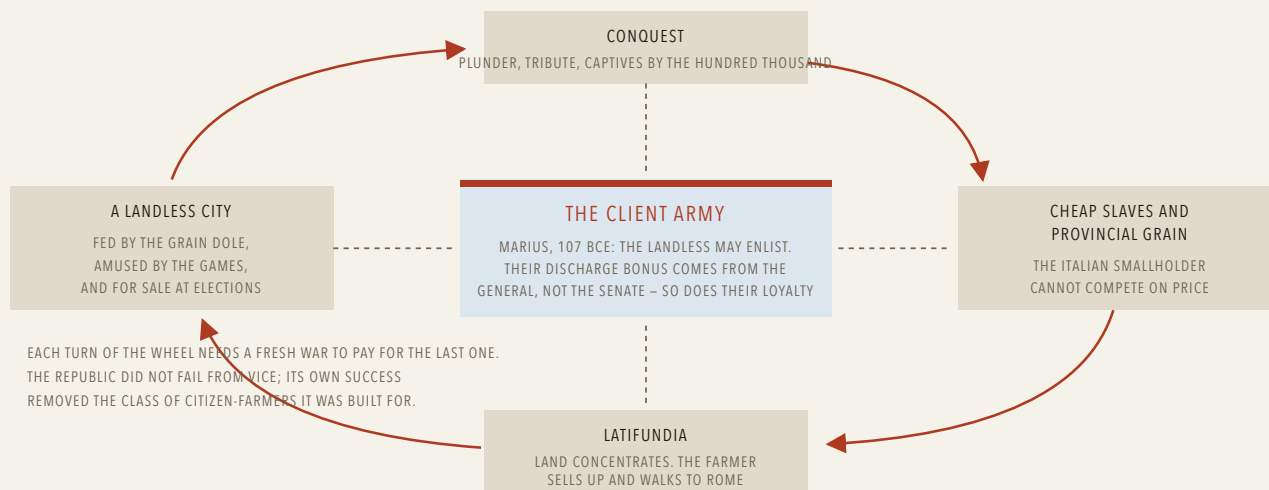


Durant treats the Republic's constitution as a set of devices for preventing any individual from becoming indispensable. Conquest destroyed it by making individuals indispensable – Scipio, then Marius, then Sulla, Pompey, Caesar. No clause had been written against that.

The conquests of the third and second centuries — Carthage, Macedon, Greece, Asia, Spain — made Rome rich and destroyed the society that had won them. Durant lays out the mechanism plainly, and it is the same fiscal-agrarian mechanism he applied to Egypt and to China. Cheap slaves and cheap provincial grain make the small Italian farm unprofitable; the farmer sells to a neighbour with capital; the great estate — *latifundium* — spreads; the dispossessed go to Rome, where they must be fed and

entertained; and the army, which used to be an army of smallholders defending their own fields, becomes a body of landless men whose pension depends on their general.

PLATE 23 THE LOOP THAT ATE THE REPUBLIC



The Gracchi – Tiberius in 133, Gaius in 123 – tried to break the loop by redistributing public land, and both were killed by senatorial mobs. Durant marks those two deaths as the moment the Republic's politics became lethal, and the century from 133 to 31 as one long consequence.

Bk. II

The Revolution

133 – 27 BCE

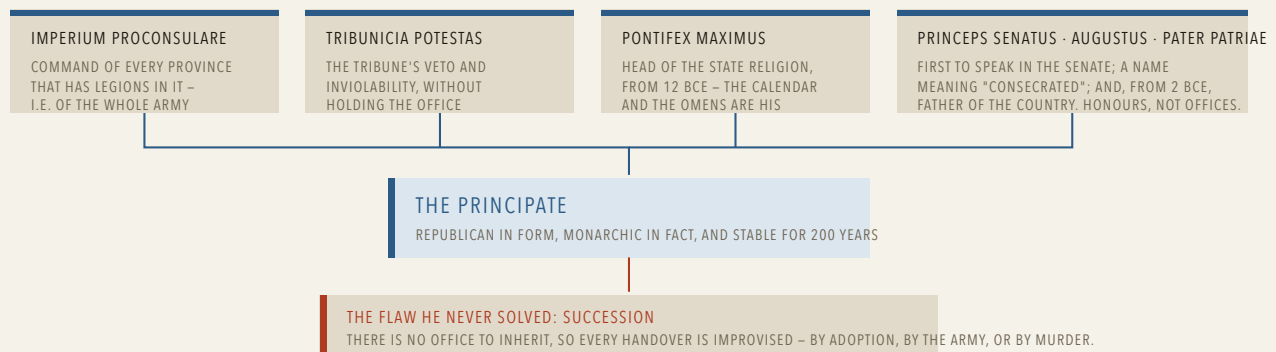
PLATE 24 A HUNDRED YEARS OF FALLING APART



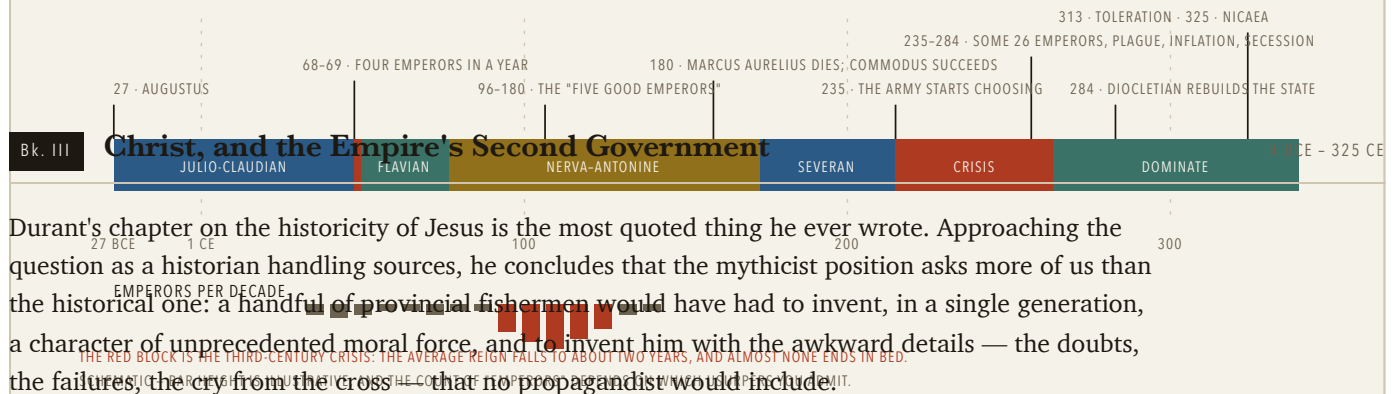
EACH STRONGMAN IS INSTALLED TO END THE DISORDER THE LAST ONE CAUSED, AND EACH SOLUTION NEEDS MORE CONCENTRATED POWER THAN THE LAST. THE REPUBLIC IS NOT OVERTHROWN ONCE BUT FIVE TIMES – AND THE FIFTH HOLDS.

Caesar himself receives a long and admiring portrait – Durant thinks him the most complete man of action in the ancient record, and thinks his assassination pointless, because by 44 the Republic being defended had not existed for two generations.

HE ABOLISHED NOTHING. HE COLLECTED.



Durant's admiration for Augustus is for the political artistry rather than the man: he gave a republic-worshipping aristocracy a monarchy it could vote for, and bought two centuries of peace with a legal fiction that no one was required to believe and no one was permitted to deny.



Durant's chapter on the historicity of Jesus is the most quoted thing he ever wrote. Approaching the question as a historian handling sources, he concludes that the mythicist position asks more of us than the historical one: a handful of provincial fishermen would have had to invent, in a single generation, a character of unprecedented moral force, and to invent him with the awkward details — the doubts, the failures, the cry from the cross — that no propagandist would include.

"That a few simple men should in one generation have invented so powerful and appealing a personality, so lofty an ethic and so inspiring a vision of human brotherhood, would be a miracle far more incredible than any recorded in the Gospels."

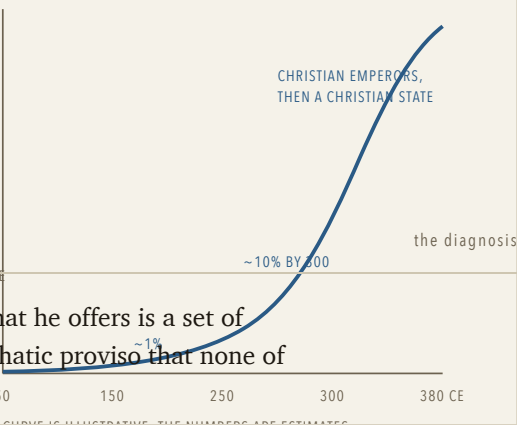
WILL DURANT · CAESAR AND CHRIST

He then separates the founder from the institution with equal firmness. Jesus preached an imminent kingdom to Jews in Galilee; **Paul** built a universal religion out of it for gentiles, dropped the ritual law, made the crucifixion the centre rather than the ending, and carried it into the Greek cities. Durant is explicit: without Paul the movement remains a Jewish sect, and Volume III has no second half.

THE COMPETITORS, C. 200 CE

	OPEN TO	DEMANDS	ORGANISED	EXCLUSIVE
IMPERIAL CULT	ALL, FORMALLY	NOTHING	STATE	NO
MITHRAS	MEN, SOLDIERS	INITIATION	LODGES	NO
ISIS	ALL, AT A PRICE	FEES, RITES	TEMPLES	NO
CHRISTIANITY	ALL, INCLUDING SLAVES	A WHOLE LIFE	A HIERARCHY	ABSOLUTELY

SHARE OF THE EMPIRE'S POPULATION



Bk. IV

Why Rome Fell

DURANT'S ACCOUNT OF THE ADVANTAGE IS UNSENTIMENTAL AND HAS FOUR PARTS: IT TOOK ANYONE, INCLUDING THE PEOPLE THE OTHER CULTS EXCLUDED; IT ASKED ENOUGH TO CREATE REAL COMMITMENT; IT BUILT AN ADMINISTRATIVE STRUCTURE – HEDGE BY ALSO SACRIFICING ELSEWHERE. SO EVERY CONVERT WAS A PERMANENT LOSS TO THE COMPETITION. PERSECUTION HELPED RATHER THAN HINDERED: IT WAS INTERMITTENT, LOCALLY APPLIED, AND PRODUCED MARTYRS WHOSE DEATHS WERE MORE EFFECTIVE THAN ANY OTHERS. THE STRUCTURE WAS ALREADY HOLLOW. CONSTANTINE IN 303.

Durant devotes a full chapter to the question and refuses a single answer. What he offers is a set of simultaneous failures, each of which made the others worse – with the emphatic proviso that none of them is the barbarians, who arrived at a structure already hollow.



Read the plate as a system rather than a list: debasement raises taxes, taxes drive men off the land, depopulation shortens the army, a shorter army needs federate troops, federates need paying, and payment requires more debasement. Durant's contribution is less any single cause than the insistence that they are one process.

ON CHRISTIANITY AND THE FALL

Against Gibbon, Durant holds that the new religion was a symptom rather than a cause: "Rome was not destroyed by Christianity, any more than by barbarian invasion; it was an empty shell when Christianity rose to influence and invasion came." What the Church did do – and this is the bridge into Volume IV – was inherit the administrative habits of the empire it outlived: dioceses, a Latin chancery, a legal mind, and a capital at Rome.

The Age of Faith

Medieval civilization — Christian, Islamic and Judaic — from Constantine to Dante, A.D. 325–1300.

SPAN	ARGUMENT	UNUSUAL FOR 1950	ENDS WITH
325 – 1300 CE	Three heirs, one inheritance	Islam gets ~250 pp.	Dante

This is the volume in which Durant is most clearly ahead of the historiography of his day. Where standard mid-century surveys treated the Middle Ages as a European interval between two classical ages, Durant gives roughly equal standing to three civilizations dividing the Roman inheritance — and awards the palm, for most of the period, to the one his readers knew least. **Between about 700 and 1200 the leading civilization on earth, by nearly every measure he applies, was Islamic.**

PLATE 29 THREE HEIRS OF ROME, C. 800 CE

	BYZANTIUM	THE CALIPHATE	LATIN CHRISTENDOM
	CONTINUITY	EXPANSION	RECONSTRUCTION
CAPITAL	CONSTANTINOPLE	BAGHDAD, FOUNDED 762	AACHEN – A PALACE, NOT A CITY
STATE	UNBROKEN ROMAN LAW AND BUREAUCRACY; AN EMPEROR	CALIPH, VIZIERS, A PAID ARMY, A PAPER BUREAUCRACY	PERSONAL LORDSHIP; ALMOST NO SALARIED OFFICIALS
LEARNING	GREEK TEXTS PRESERVED, RARELY EXTENDED	GREEK, PERSIAN AND INDIAN LEARNING TRANSLATED AND ADVANCED	A FEW MONASTIC LIBRARIES; LITERACY NEARLY CONFINED TO CLERGY
ECONOMY	GOLD SOLIDUS STABLE FOR 700 YEARS; STATE MONOPOLIES	BANKING, CHEQUES, CREDIT; TRADE FROM SPAIN TO CHINA	BARTER AND THE MANOR; COINAGE THIN, ROADS DECAYED
LARGEST CITY	CONSTANTINOPLE PERHAPS 300,000	BAGHDAD – POSSIBLY THE FIRST CITY OF A MILLION	ROME – DOWN FROM A MILLION TO PERHAPS 25,000
FATE	SURVIVES TO 1453 – GUTTED BY FELLOW CHRISTIANS IN 1204	POLITICAL UNITY GONE BY 900; CULTURAL LEADERSHIP HELD TO C. 1200	THE POOREST OF THE THREE – AND THE ONE THAT WILL OVERTAKE BOTH

Durant's framing device for the whole volume, and the reason it is worth reading even where the detail has dated. Numbers here are the order-of-magnitude estimates historians work with, not censuses. The last row is the question the remaining 900 pages exist to answer.

Bk. I Byzantium and Islam

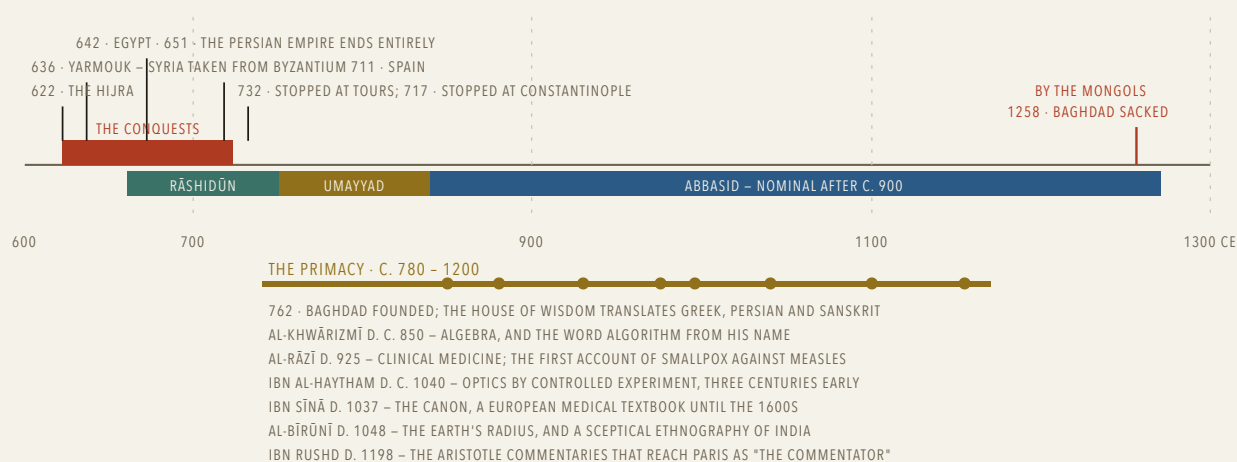
325 – 1258

Byzantium gets respect rather than affection. Durant credits it with three things the West could not have done without: it preserved the Greek texts, it held the eastern frontier for eight centuries while Europe was in no condition to, and under Justinian it codified Roman law into the *Corpus Juris Civilis* — which, rediscovered at Bologna in the eleventh century, becomes the basis of the legal systems of most of continental Europe.

On Islam he is expansive, and deliberately so. He devotes about a quarter of a very long book to it, and the tone is one of a man correcting an omission. The section on Muhammad is respectful and biographical; the sections on the sciences are enthusiastic; and the chapters on Córdoba under the

Umayyads describe a city with paved and lit streets, public baths, and a library catalogue running to forty-four volumes, at a moment when Paris had none of these.

PLATE 30 ISLAM · A CENTURY OF CONQUEST, FIVE OF PRIMACY



Durant's judgement on why the primacy ended is tentative and worth flagging as contested: he points to the Mongol destruction, to the closing of independent reasoning in theology, and to the shift of trade routes. Modern historians dispute all three weightings; the fact of the primacy itself is not in dispute.

THE JUDAIC THREAD

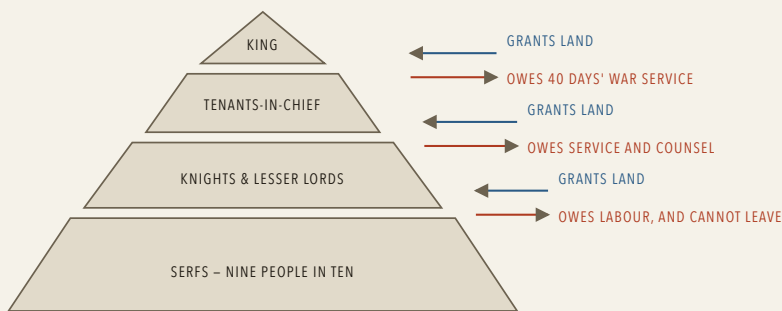
Durant – himself raised Catholic, and married to a Jewish woman – insists on treating Judaism as a third medieval civilization rather than a minority within the other two. The Talmud is presented as a vast legal-intellectual achievement produced without a state; Maimonides (1135-1204), writing in Arabic in Cairo, is placed alongside Averroes and Aquinas as one of the three great reconcilers of Aristotle with revelation. The chapters on massacre and expulsion – the Rhineland in 1096, England in 1290 – are not softened.

Bk. II The West Rebuilds

500 – 1200

With the state gone, two institutions organise western life: the manor, which solves the problem of food, and the Church, which solves everything else — courts, schools, hospitals, records, charity, calendar and the only literate class. Feudalism, in Durant's presentation, is not a system anyone designed but the residue of a simple exchange repeated at every level of society: *land in return for service, protection in return for obedience*.

A CHAIN OF THE SAME BARGAIN



DURANT'S NOTE: IT IS A SYSTEM FOR A WORLD WITH NO CASH, NO ROADS AND NO STATE. EVERY OBLIGATION IS PERSONAL, LOCAL AND HEREDITARY, BECAUSE NOTHING MORE ABSTRACT COULD BE ENFORCED.

THE ENGINE UNDERNEATH: THREE FIELDS



EACH STRIP ROTATES THROUGH ALL THREE EACH YEAR – THE GREAT MEDIEVAL IMPROVEMENT OVER THE OLDER TWO-FIELD SYSTEM. ADD THE HEAVY PLOUGH, THE HORSE COLLAR AND THE WATER MILL, AND YIELDS RISE ENOUGH TO FEED TOWNS AGAIN FROM C. 1000.

WHY THIS MATTERS TO THE VOLUME

DURANT MAKES THE AGRICULTURAL RECOVERY THE PRECONDITION FOR EVERYTHING HE ADMIRES AFTER 1100 – TOWNS, FAIRS, UNIVERSITIES, CATHEDRALS.

The pairing is deliberate. Durant's Middle Ages do not begin to move until the food supply does, and he dates the whole twelfth-century revival – legal, architectural, philosophical – to a surplus produced by three unglamorous inventions in ploughing, harnessing and crop rotation.

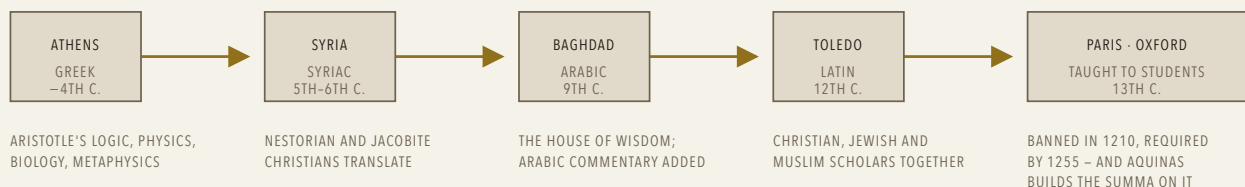
THE CRUSADES, IN THE LEDGER

Durant's treatment is cool to the point of bleakness. He grants the sincerity of the motive, notes the mixture of piety, land-hunger and papal politics, and then simply totals the results — two centuries, an enormous expenditure of life, and a permanent poisoning of relations between three religions, in exchange for territory held for less than a century and a body of knowledge that was already reaching Europe by the quieter route through Spain and Sicily.

The Medieval Mind

CRUSADE	DATE	AIM	RESULT	VERDICT
FIRST	1095-99	TAKE JERUSALEM	TAKEN IN 1099; THE POPULATION MASSACRED	WON
SECOND	1147-49	RECOVER EDESSA	NEVER REACHED IT; ATTACKED DAMASCUS, AN ALLY, AND FAILED	FAILED

The last third of the volume is Durant at his best. His claim is that the "age of faith" produced, out of its own internal pressures, the instrument that would eventually dissolve it: a technique of systematic argument, developed to defend doctrine, which turned out to work on anything.



ROUGHLY 1,600 YEARS AND FOUR LANGUAGES. ALMOST NONE OF IT REACHES EUROPE BY THE DIRECT GREEK ROUTE – WHICH IS WHY DURANT TREATS THE ISLAMIC CHAPTERS AS LOAD-BEARING FOR THE CHRISTIAN ONES RATHER THAN AS A COURTESY, AND WHY AVERROES APPEARS IN LATIN CHRISTENDOM SIMPLY AS "THE COMMENTATOR."

THE MEDIEVAL WEST DID NOT REDISCOVER ANTIQUITY SO MUCH AS RECEIVE IT, TRANSLATED, FROM PEOPLE IT WAS SIMULTANEOUSLY AT WAR WITH.

Sicily is the second channel and Durant gives it due weight – a Norman court where Arabic, Greek and Latin were all chancery languages, and where Frederick II presided over exactly the kind of mixed intellectual world the crusading impulse was busy destroying elsewhere.

PLATE 34 FAITH AND REASON · THREE SETTLEMENTS

ANSELM · D. 1109

"CREDO UT INTELLIGAM" – I BELIEVE
IN ORDER THAT I MAY UNDERSTAND.

FAITH COMES FIRST AND REASON THEN
EXPLORES IT. REASON CANNOT REACH A
CONCLUSION FAITH HAS NOT ALREADY GIVEN.

ABELARD · D. 1142

SIC ET NON LISTS 158 QUESTIONS AND,
FOR EACH, AUTHORITIES ON BOTH SIDES.

"BY DOUBTING WE COME TO INQUIRY;
BY INQUIRY WE PERCEIVE THE TRUTH."
CONDEMNED TWICE. THE METHOD SURVIVES.

AQUINAS · D. 1274

THE GREAT SYNTHESIS: REASON AND
REVELATION CANNOT CONFLICT, SINCE BOTH
COME FROM GOD. REASON REACHES SOME
TRUTHS UNAIDED; REVELATION SUPPLIES THE
REST. EACH IS SOVEREIGN IN ITS DOMAIN.

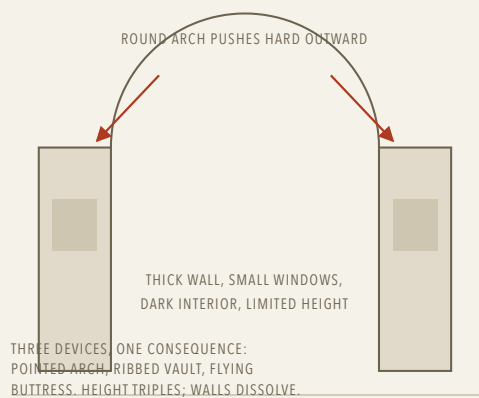
THE INSTABILITY DURANT POINTS TO

A TOOL BUILT TO SERVE THEOLOGY AND DECLARED SOVEREIGN IN ITS OWN DOMAIN DOES NOT STAY IN THAT DOMAIN.

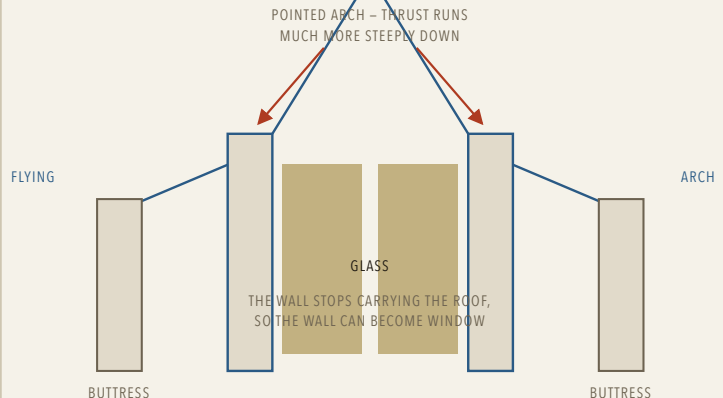
This is the hinge of the volume and the bridge to Volume V. Aquinas's settlement is generous to reason precisely because he is confident it will agree with faith; within three centuries the same licence is being used by people who are not confident of that at all.

PLATE 35 THE CATHEDRAL AS AN ARGUMENT IN STONE

ROMANESQUE · TO C. 1140



GOTHIC · FROM SAINT-DENIS, 1140S



Durant reads the cathedral the way he reads the *Summa* – as a solution engineered under a constraint, in which the aesthetic result and the structural logic are the same fact. Chartres and the *Summa Theologiae* are contemporaries, and he treats that as more than coincidence.

The volume closes with Dante, and the choice is an argument. The *Commedia* is written in the vernacular rather than Latin; it puts popes in Hell on the poet's own authority; it is structured with scholastic precision and animated by an entirely personal love. For Durant it is the age of faith completing itself and, in the same gesture, handing over to something else.

Read consecutively, the four volumes keep producing the same shapes in different materials. Durant does not present these as laws — Volume I is explicit that the record is too thin for laws — but he returns to them often enough that they function as the working theory of the series.

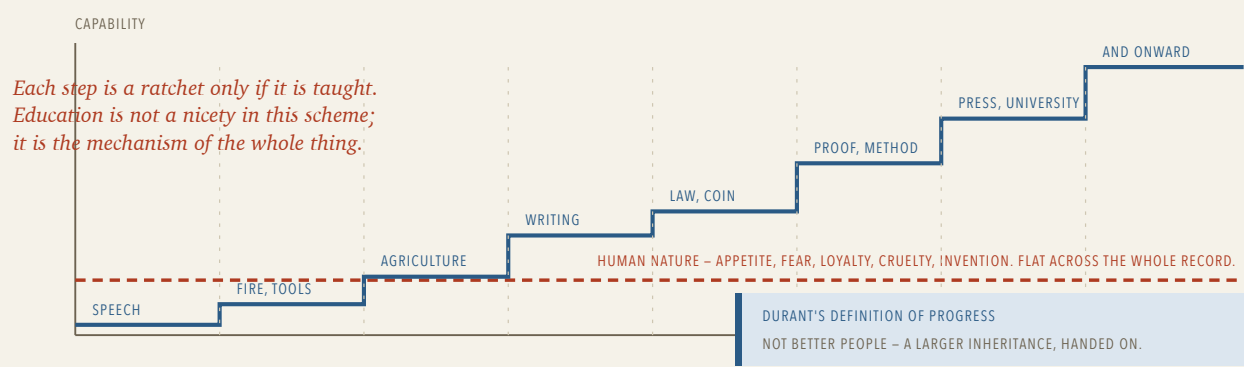
PLATE 36 THE SAME COLLAPSE, FOUR TIMES

		EGYPT	HAN CHINA	ROME	ABBASIDS
STAGE 1	LAND CONCENTRATES IN FEWER HANDS	NOMARCHS	MAGNATES	LATIFUNDIA	IQṬĀ' GRANTS
STAGE 2	GREAT ESTATES ESCAPE TAXATION	TEMPLE LANDS	EXEMPT ESTATES	SENATORIAL ESTATES	TAX FARMS
STAGE 3	REVENUE FALLS; THE BURDEN SHIFTS DOWN	YES	YES	YES	YES
STAGE 4	SMALLHOLDERS QUIT, OR ARE TIED TO THE SOIL	CORVÉE FLIGHT	TENANCY	THE COLONUS	PEASANT FLIGHT
STAGE 5	THE ARMY SHRINKS OR IS HIRED FROM OUTSIDE	NUBIAN, LIBYAN TROOPS	STEPPE CAVALRY	FEDERATE GERMANS	TURKISH GHILMĀN
STAGE 6	A SHOCK ARRIVES THAT WOULD ONCE HAVE BEEN ABSORBED	HYKSOS, SEA PEOPLES	YELLOW TURBANS	THE RHINE CROSSING	THE MONGOLS

THE FINAL SHOCK DIFFERS EVERY TIME AND GETS THE BLAME EVERY TIME. DURANT'S ARGUMENT IS THAT STAGES 1 TO 5 DECIDE THE OUTCOME, AND THAT THEY ARE FISCAL AND AGRARIAN LONG BEFORE THEY ARE MILITARY.

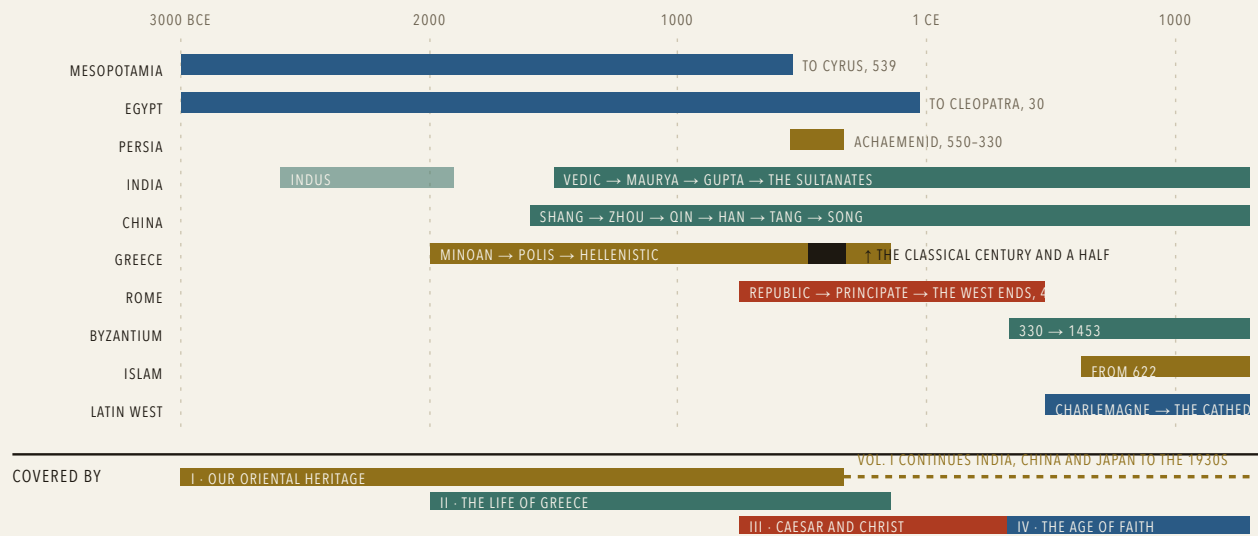
Whether the parallel holds as tightly as the grid suggests is a fair question – each column compresses centuries and a large scholarly literature. But it is the single most transferable idea in the four volumes, and it is what the Durants later generalise in *The Lessons of History* as the concentration and redistribution of wealth.

PLATE 37 THE ONLY THING THAT ACCUMULATES



This is the conclusion the Durants reach at the end of eleven volumes, stated here in the form it takes across the first four. Civilizations rise and fall; the transmitted stock of technique and knowledge does not fall with them, provided somebody – a monastery, a House of Wisdom, a university – keeps copying.

PLATE 38 ALL FOUR VOLUMES ON ONE LINE



The overlaps are the design. Durant follows each civilization to its own conclusion rather than cutting the world into centuries, which is why Volume I ends in the twentieth century for Asia and in 330 BCE for Persia, and why Volumes II and III cover the same two hundred years from opposite ends of the Mediterranean.

SIX RECURRING PROPOSITIONS

01 Order precedes everything.

Nothing
is
created
where
life and
property
are
insecure.
Durant's
civilizations
do not
decline
into
anarchy;
they
decline
because
the
fiscal
and
legal
basis of
order
fails
first,
and the
anarchy
follows.

02 **Wealth concentrates until it is redistributed.**

By law,
as in
Solon's
cancellation
of
debts,
or by
revolt,
as with
the
Gracchi
and the
Yellow
Turbans.
Egypt,
Rome,
Han
China
and the
Abbasids
all fail
at the
same
point in
the
cycle.

03 **Freedom and order trade against each other.**

Athens
buys
creativity
with
instability;
Sparta
and Qin
buy
stability
by
suppressing
the
thing
that
makes a
civilization
worth
studying.
Durant
thinks
the
optimum
drifts
with
circumstance,
and
moves
toward
order
under
external
threat.

04 **Moral codes are adaptations, and they lag.**

Hunting
morality,
agricultural
morality
and
industrial
morality
each
serve
their
economy,
and
each
survives
into the
next
epoch
as an
apparent
decline
in
virtue.

05 **Religion recovers whenever the state fails to deliver.**

Declared
finished
after the
Sophists,
after
Lucretius,
after the
Enlightenment
– and
back
each
time.
Durant
treats it
as
functional
rather
than as
a
mistake:
it
supplies
meaning
and
social
discipline
that no
state
has
managed
without.

06 **Only the heritage accumulates.**

Human
capacity
is flat;
the
inheritance
is not.
This is
Durant's
one
unambiguous
form of
progress,
and it
makes
teaching
the
load-
bearing
activity
of any
civilization.

01 The archaeology has moved a long way

Volume II was written before Linear B was deciphered, so Durant's Mycenaeans are not yet Greeks. Volume I predates radiocarbon dating entirely, the mature excavation of the Indus cities, and most of what is now known about Anatolia and the Levant. Read the narrative for its shape; check any specific date or attribution against something current.

02 The "Aryan invasion" and the race language of the 1930s

Volume I uses a framework of migrating races and inherited national temperaments that was standard when it was written and is not now. Durant is consistently anti-racist in his conclusions – he argues explicitly that circumstance rather than blood explains cultural difference – but the vocabulary he argues in is period vocabulary, and the Indo-European migration model has been substantially revised.

03 A famous sentence about India worth knowing before you meet it

Durant calls the Muslim conquest of India "probably the bloodiest story in history." The line is frequently quoted today in polemical contexts that have nothing to do with him. It sits in a volume that is otherwise unusually generous to Islamic civilization, and it rests on chronicle figures modern historians treat as unreliable. Treat it as a judgement of its time rather than a finding.

04 Great men do a lot of work

Durant knows the objection and answers it – the man of genius is "the child of his time" who nevertheless redirects it – but the narrative still moves through Hammurabi, Pericles, Caesar, Muhammad, Aquinas. Structural and material history, and the history of ordinary and of women's lives, get real attention by the standards of 1940 and thin attention by ours.

05 No footnotes worth the name

References are sparse and often to secondary works now superseded. This is popular synthesis by a philosopher, not a monograph, and Durant said so. It is a superb map and a poor citation.

06 Environmental and cyclical determinism, applied confidently

The Nile-versus-Euphrates argument, the dynastic cycle, the recurring life-course of civilizations: these are elegant, they explain a great deal, and they are close to untestable. They are best held as organising hypotheses – which, in fairness, is roughly how Durant holds them in his more careful moments.

WHAT HOLDS UP

The comparative sweep, which almost nobody attempts any more; the integration of art, thought and economics in one narrative; the fiscal-agrarian account of decline, which has aged remarkably well; the refusal of European exceptionalism in Volume I; and the treatment of Islamic and Judaic civilization in Volume IV, which was well ahead of the anglophone field in 1950. And the prose, which is the actual reason people finish four thousand pages.

A PRACTICAL READING ORDER

- **If you read one:** Volume III, *Caesar and Christ*. It is the most tightly argued and the most self-contained.
- **If you read two:** add Volume IV, *The Age of Faith* — the most original, and the one whose subject the general reader is least likely to know.
- **Volume I** is best sampled: Part I on the establishment of civilization and the chapters on China and India repay full reading; the Near Eastern middle is where the dated archaeology is thickest.
- **Volume II** is the most conventional in coverage and the most enjoyable to read straight through.
- **Before or after:** *The Lessons of History* (1968) is the hundred-page distillation of all eleven volumes, and the two Durants wrote it together.

COLOPHON

The Story of Civilization, I–IV

A reader's summary of four volumes by Will Durant, published by Simon & Schuster between 1935 and 1950. Every plate in this document was drawn for it; none is reproduced from the books, which contain photographic plates rather than diagrams. Figures given as estimates are the ranges historians currently work with, and are marked as such where they carry weight in an argument.

VOLUMES SUMMARISED

- I · Our Oriental Heritage, 1935
- II · The Life of Greece, 1939
- III · Caesar and Christ, 1944
- IV · The Age of Faith, 1950

PLATES

38 hand-drawn figures
All vector; all legible at print size

COMPANION

Livy · The History of Rome
Books 1–10 and 21–45, in a second document

ALSO IN THIS SERIES

The Lessons of History · Durant
Guns, Germs and Steel · Diamond